

Creative & Effective Presentations in PowerPoint



Digital Integration Teaching Initiative (DITI)
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Digital Integration Teaching Initiative
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GRMN3800 | Summer 2026

Workshop Agenda & Outline

- Learn guidelines, best practices, and tips for making a PowerPoint presentation.
- Explore options for advanced design.
- Learn how to consider accessibility in designing presentations.

For more information, see: <https://bit.ly/handout-powerpoint>

Getting Started: The Basics

Introduction to PowerPoint

- Microsoft PowerPoint is a presentation program for Windows, Mac, or mobile devices.
- It can create presentations from scratch or from a template.
- Users can add text, images, and videos; use professional designs with PowerPoint Designer; and add transitions, animations, and motion. Presentations can be saved to OneDrive and shared with others.
- If you are a member of the Northeastern community, PowerPoint is available with [Northeastern's Microsoft 365 subscription](#). See: [installation instructions for Mac](#) and [instructions for Windows](#).

What design features make for an effective presentation?

- The same features that make for effective advertising!
- What do IKEA and Google have in common?
 - Simple and effective design



Organize your Presentation

- Treat your presentation like any other form of argument, explanation, or narrative— be intentional, and **organize your slides carefully!**
- **Put main ideas front-and-center on the slides.** Additional detail can go in the “Notes” section.
- **Use signposts** to orient your audience.

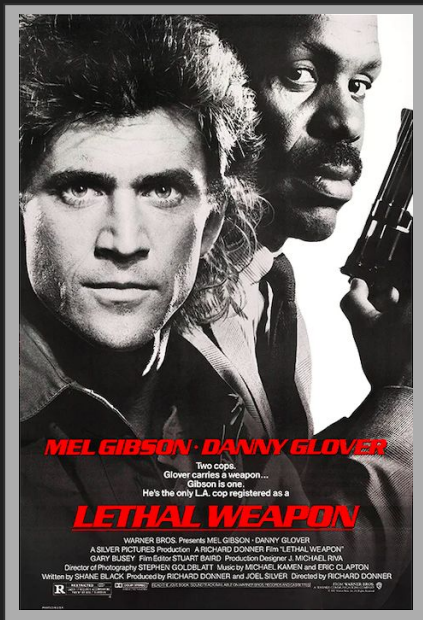
Keep it Simple

- **Less is more.**
- Slides should be **clear, concise**, and above all, **understandable**.
- Nothing in your slide should be superfluous, ever!
- Slides need plenty of “negative space.”

Compare the two slides that follow. Which do you think is more effective? Why?

Blockbuster Movie Posters: Then vs Now

1987



Core characters

Single shot with minimal editing

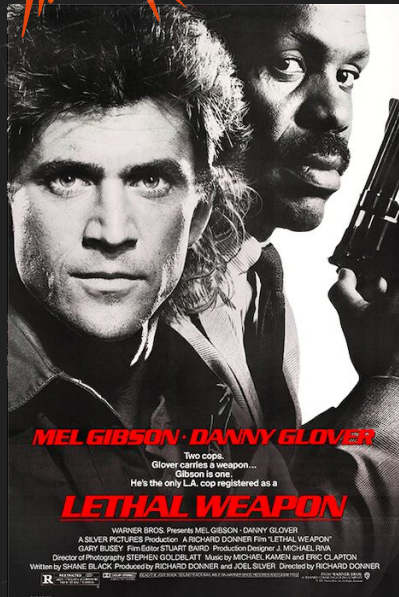
2023



Most, if not all, named characters

Distinct headshots digitally superimposed

Blockbuster Movie Poster Design Trends Have Changed Greatly Over 40 Years



1987

Posters that once featured only core characters originally posed in a single shot frame have now become posters that feature most if not all named characters presented through distinct headshots superimposed during post-editing. This reflects a film industry that has fallen into deeper and deeper dependence on digital technology for the benefit of production efficiency. Personally I find it a loss in the artistic merit of these marketing objects which possibly reflects a similar artistic loss in the films themselves. In this way the change in how posters get made functions as a metonymy for how the film industry as a whole has evolved. The use of *Mission: Impossible - Dead Reckoning Part One* here is in a way ironic, since lately Tom Cruise's entire career seems to revolve around an implicit critique of the very digital overdependence his own film's poster perfectly reflects. It's hard to say, then, to what degree I can take this critique seriously regardless of how many cliffs he drives a motorcycle off of.

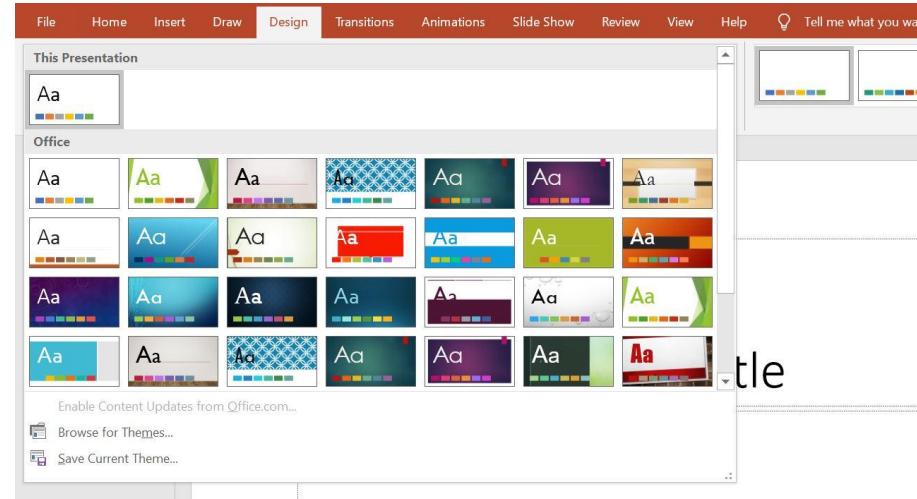


2023

Getting Started: Presentation Design and Master Slides

Design: Select Theme

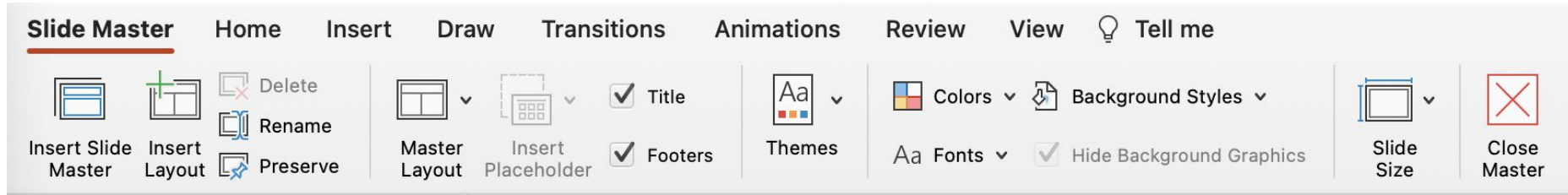
- Design templates contain color schemes, slide and title masters with custom formatting, and styled fonts.
 - Select the **Design** tab.
 - Select one of the **Themes**—click on the down arrow with a line over it for the drop-down menu.
 - Select one of the **Variants**.



Master Slides

Master Slides provide your presentation with a consistent and professional look.

To set up Master Slides, go into “View” and choose “Slide Master” from the “Master” menu.



Master Slide Templates

Click to edit Master title style

- Click to edit Master text styles
 - Second level
 - Third level
 - Fourth level
 - Fifth level

6/4/21

Footer

Click to edit Master title style

Click to edit Master text styles

- Click to edit Master text styles
 - Second level
 - Third level
 - Fourth level
 - Fifth level



Click to edit Master title style

- Click to edit Master text styles
 - Second level
 - Third level
 - Fourth level
 - Fifth level



6/4/21

Footer

- Click to edit Master text styles
 - Second level
 - Third level
 - Fourth level
 - Fifth level



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Footer

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Presentation Tips: Text

Keep it Visible: Fonts

- Sans serif fonts are typically the best for presentations.
- Be generous with spacing.
- No more than two complementary fonts (e.g., Arial and **Arial Bold** for emphasis).
- Use mixed case, not all CAPS.
- **Bold** vs. Underline vs. *Italics*.

Times New Roman: Keep it Visible

EB Garamond: Keep it Visible

Arial: Keep it Visible

Droid Sans: Keep it Visible

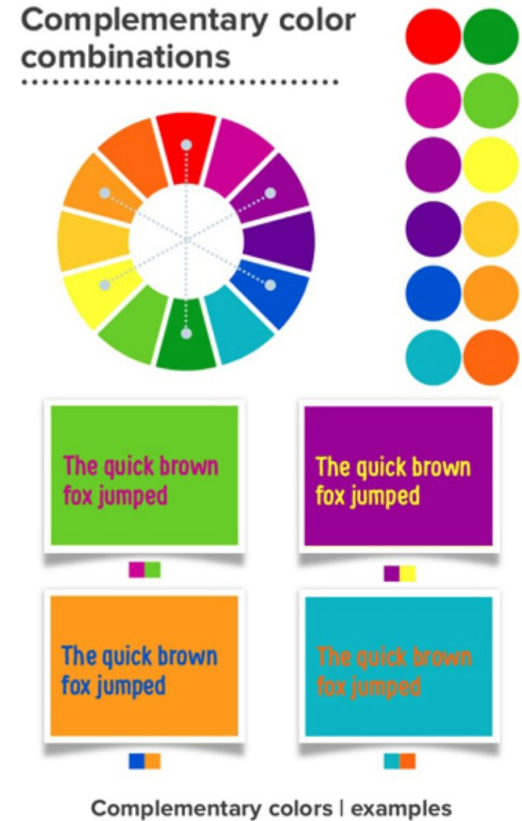
Caveat: Keep it Visible

Comic: Keep it Visible

Cambria: Keep it Visible

Keep it Visible: Colors

- Make color choices that are accessible to everyone (and appropriate for the presentation).
- Ideal color schemes are **high contrast**.
 - Limit your palette to 3 colors total.
 - PowerPoint offers multiple color palettes.
 - [NU Colors](#) offers a university palette.

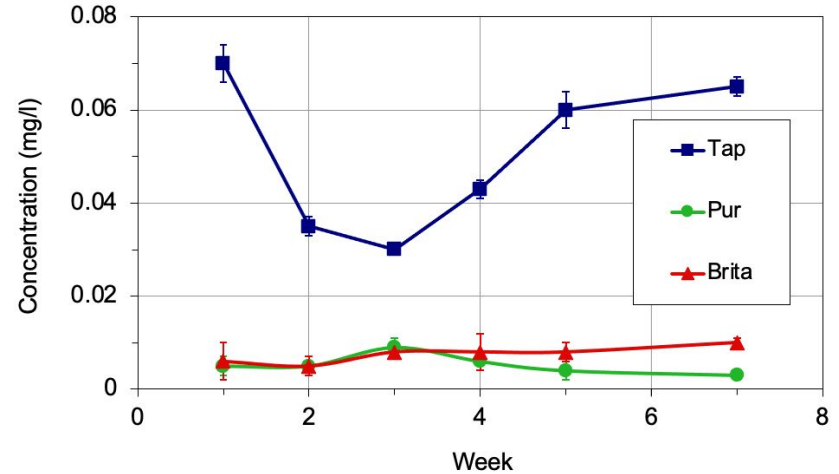
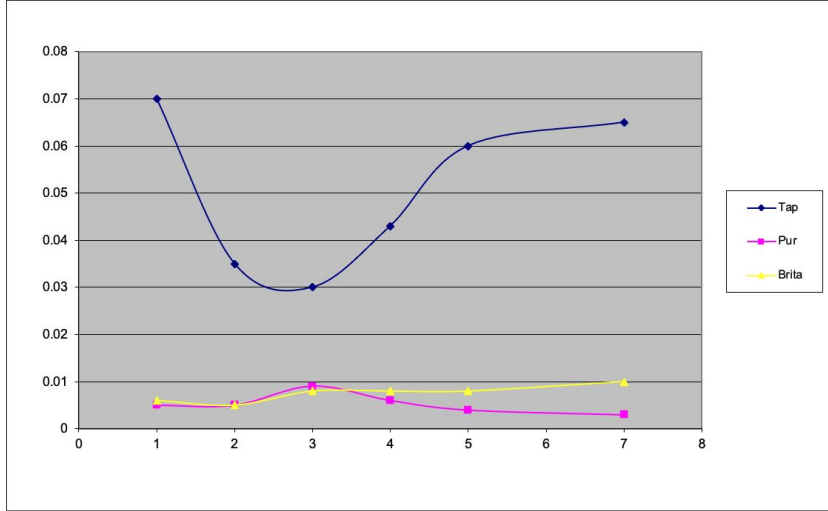


Presentation Tips: Images

Use Graphics & Charts

- Graphs and charts are a great way to communicate complex information.
- You can add many kinds of charts to your presentation:
 - Bar charts, trend lines, pie charts, scatter plots, spider charts, and more.
- The graphics and charts should be of high-quality, accurate, and self-explanatory.

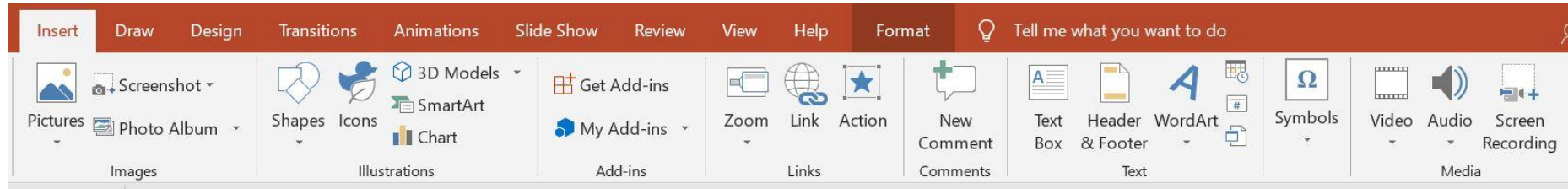
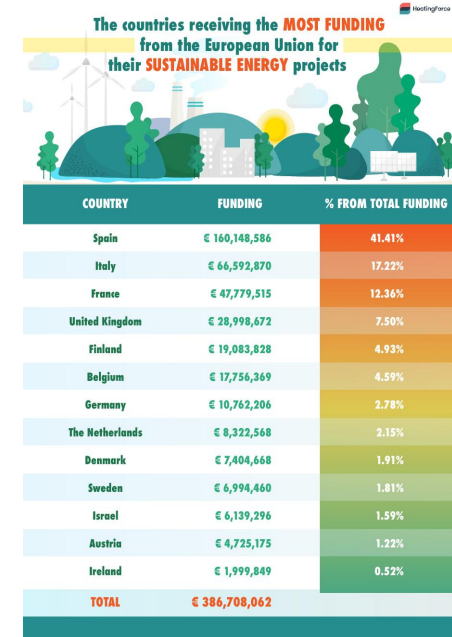
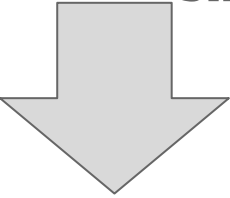
Graphics & Charts: Readability is Key



The graph on the right is easier to read!

Inserting Images

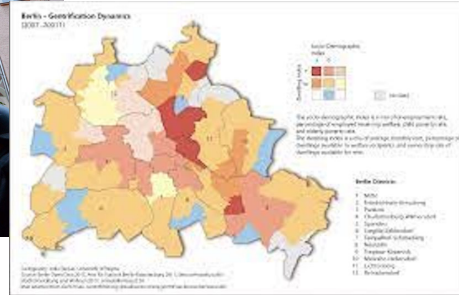
- Use the 'Insert' option to add images:
Pictures, Screenshots, Photos; and
Illustrations: Shapes, Icons, 3D Models,
SmartArt and Charts.



Graphics & Charts: Keep it Simple



VS.



Remember that a single image is far more powerful than a slide cluttered with images.

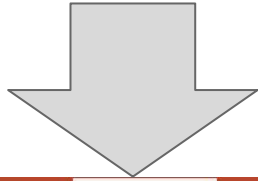
Presentation Tips: Animation Effects & Transitions

Use Animations Judiciously

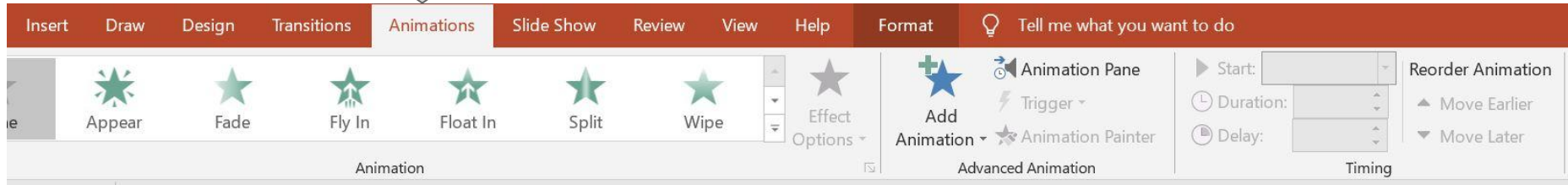
- Animations can add flair to your slide transitions.
- Some types, like Appear, Fade-in, and Fade-out are subtle, while others like Spin or Fly-In can be very busy.
- Using too many of animations can make the presentation look less serious.
 - Animations should only be used if they improve your presentation style and enhance your communication of highly technical or complex information.

Adding Animation Effects

- There are three types of animations: **entrance**, **emphasis**, and **exit**. To use advanced PowerPoint animations, click on the drop-down arrow for “Add Animation” (where the plus sign and blue star icon is located).

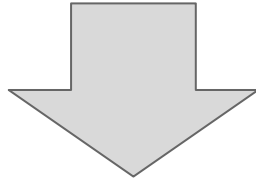


Animations are located here on the taskbar.



Adding Slide Transitions

- Slide transitions animate the movement from one slide to the next. To use PowerPoint transitions, click on the drop-down arrow for “Transitions.”



Transitions are located here on the taskbar.

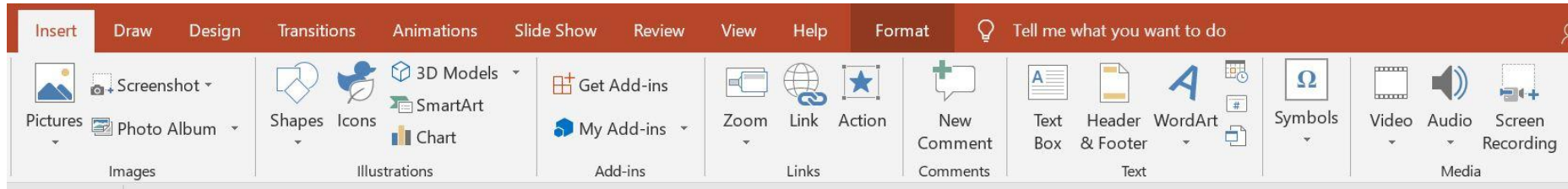
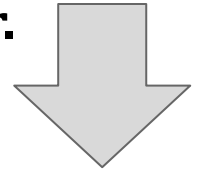


Presentation Tips: Audio, Video, & VoiceOver

Use Audio/Video for Impact

- You can upload audio from your computer or record it within PowerPoint.
- To add video, you can link to an online video or upload one saved to your computer.
- Bear in mind that adding audio and video components may cause display issues during presentations.

Audio and video are available at the top-right when you click “Insert” on the taskbar.

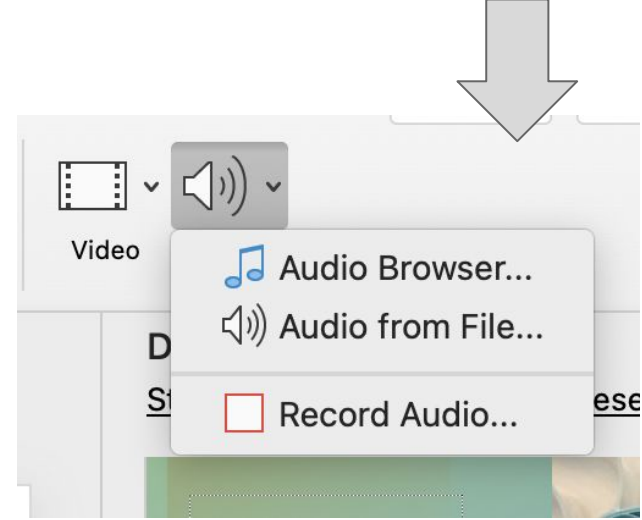


Use Voiceover for Impact



Voiceover is available at the top-right when you click “Insert” on the taskbar.

- Click “Record Audio” on the dropdown menu for “Audio.”
- **Or** select pre-recorded audio from your computer or browser in the dropdown menu.



How Voiceover Looks on a Slide

Voice Over in PowerPoint

Demo for Professor Fuchs' Summer 2021 Class



Voice Over in PowerPoint

Demo for Professor Fuchs' Summer 2021 Class



Advanced PowerPoint: *Designer* & Accessibility Checker

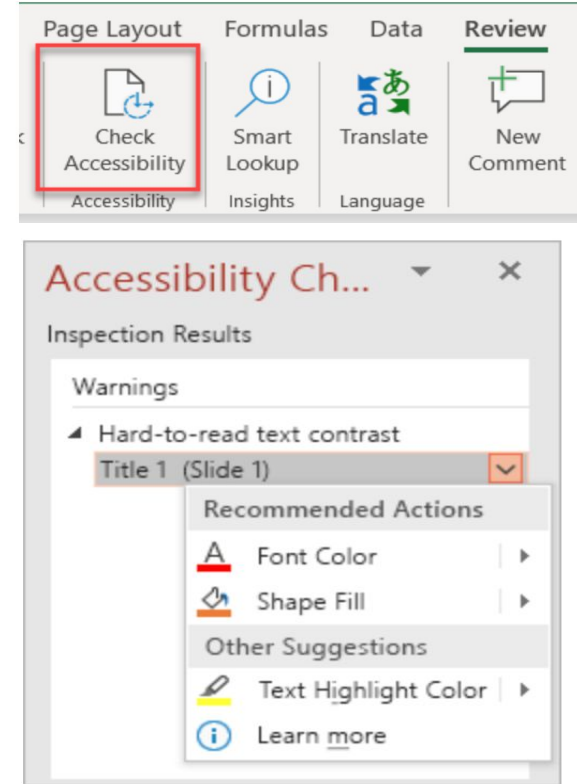
Using PowerPoint *Designer*

- Designer automatically generates design ideas for you to choose from.
 - Insert one or more pictures, a list of items, or a list of dates.
 - The **Designer** panel will open.
 - Select the design you want.
 - You can also bring up Designer by selecting a picture, and then selecting **Design > Design Ideas**.



Improve Accessibility

- **Accessibility Checker** verifies your presentation against a set of standards that identify possible areas of concern. **Find it under the 'Review' tab.**
 - This can be done when you have completed your project, **or**
 - You can get notified of issues as you are working.



For more information on accessibility, please see: <https://bit.ly/accessibility-DITI-handout>

Essential Considerations

Be Consistent & Organized

- **Be intentional** about design choices, and *keep it simple!*
- **Be consistent** in font, font size, color scheme, animation effects, design, formatting, etc.
- Set up **master slides** before you build content slides.
- Organize content with section headers and **signposts**.
- **Choose images/graphics mindfully**, and **don't mix visual types** on a single slide.
- **Limit bullets & text** on slides—keep negative space.

For Further Exploration

[DITI infographics handout](#)

[DITI accessibility handout](#)

[DITI data privacy handout](#)

Thank you!

—Developed by Vaishali Kushwaha, Julianna Wessels, and Adam Tomasi

- For more information on DITI, please see: <https://bit.ly/diti-about>
- Schedule an appointment with us! <https://bit.ly/diti-meeting>
- If you have any questions, contact us at: nulab.info@gmail.com